

HEXBOARD SEQUENCER MODE DETAILED MANUAL

1. Purpose

Sequencer mode turns the HexBoard into a separate pattern sequencer without replacing Keyboard mode. Keyboard mode and Sequencer mode are deliberately split, so you can return to the normal board behavior at any time.

2. Current Sequencer Design

- Track count: 1 track
- Step count available: 32 steps
- Active playback length: 1 to 32 steps
- Notes per step: up to 4
- Length per step: stored per step
- Velocity per step: stored per step
- Output type: MIDI or onboard synth
- Storage: onboard flash files in /Sequences

3. Entering And Leaving Sequencer Mode

From the main menu, select Sequencer.

To leave Sequencer mode, open the Sequencer menu and select Keyboard.

4. Physical Layout In Sequencer Mode

4.1 Step keys

The step grid uses the first 8 playable keys from the first 4 rows:

- Row 1: steps 1-8
- Row 2: steps 9-16
- Row 3: steps 17-24
- Row 4: steps 25-32

4.2 Dedicated sequencer keys

- Top-right key: Play/Stop
- Second-row 9th key: step overview page button
- Second-row far-right key: blue action key
- Third-row far-right key: step tools picker
- Hold the top-right key for 2 seconds to show the performance monitor while held

4.3 Lower keyboard area

The lower part of the board remains playable in Sequencer mode. These keys:

- audition notes at any time
- assign or remove notes from the selected step when a step is selected

5. Selecting And Editing Steps

5.1 Selecting a step

- Press a step once to select it.

- Press the same step again to deselect it.
- The selected step blinks so it is easy to identify.

5.2 What happens when a step is selected

When a step is selected:

- the Edit overlay appears
- note keys add or remove notes from that step immediately
- the step stores notes sorted from lowest to highest
- the step can be length-edited immediately with the encoder

5.3 Empty steps

- Empty steps are dark when unselected.
- A selected empty step still blinks so it is visible.

6. Entering Notes

6.1 Live note entry

With no step selected:

- pressing lower keyboard notes auditions them only

With a step selected:

- pressing a note key auditions that note
- the note is also added to the step if it was not already there
- pressing the same note again removes it from the step

6.2 Chords

- Each step can hold up to 4 notes.
- Notes are displayed in ascending order.
- Playback sends all notes in the step together.

6.3 Tap Preview

The Tap Preview menu item controls whether tapping a step previews its stored note or chord when you select it.

- Off: tapping a step only selects it
- On: tapping a step selects it and previews its contents

7. Note Length

7.1 How to change length

- Select a step
- Turn the encoder for quick length changes
- Press the encoder to open exact length entry

The available length values are:

- 0%
- 25%
- 50%
- 75%
- 100%

- 150%
- 200%
- 250%
- 300%
- 350%
- 400%
- 500%
- 600%
- 700%
- 800%
- 900%
- 1000%

7.2 What the values mean

Length is stored as a percentage of the step duration.

- 100% means one full step
- values below 100% shorten the note
- values above 100% let the note continue across later steps
- 0% means the step will not sound

7.3 Exact length entry

Pressing the encoder while a step is selected opens the exact length screen.

In exact length mode:

- number keys are used to enter the value directly
- the first digit typed replaces the currently shown value
- up to 4 digits are allowed
- <- removes the previous digit
- CANCEL exits exact length entry without saving
- pressing the encoder saves and exits
- the physical CANCEL key is placed lower on the board to reduce accidental presses

The exact length screen shows this keypad-style layout:

- 0 1 2 3 4
- 5 6 7 8 9
- <- CANCEL

8. Transport And Playback

8.1 Play/Stop key

The top-right key toggles transport:

- red when stopped
- green when playing

Press and hold the Play/Stop key for about 2 seconds to open the performance monitor. The monitor stays visible only while the key is held and closes when the key is released.

The performance monitor shows:

- CPU load as an approximate percentage based on the audio poll interrupt load
- heap memory used versus total
- LittleFS storage used versus total

8.2 Tempo

Tempo is set in the Sequencer menu. The sequencer treats each step as a 16th-note step at the current BPM.

8.3 Steps

The Steps menu item decides how many steps are active in playback:

- minimum 1
- maximum 32

All 32 steps still remain editable even if the active playback count is lower.

8.4 Direction

Available direction modes:

- Forward: step 1 to end, then loop
- Backward: end to step 1, then loop
- Ping-Pong: runs forward to the end, then reverses back
- Random: picks any step in the active range each tick
- Brownian: moves only to neighboring steps
- Drunk: may stay still or move one step left or right

9. Output Mode

Play Type controls where the sequencer sends notes:

- MIDI: standard external MIDI behavior
- OB Synth: sends the sequence into the onboard synth engine

OB Synth uses the shared synth settings available from Synth Options.

10. Undo, Clear, And Step Tools

10.1 Blue action key

The blue action key on the far right of the second row has two jobs:

- short press: undo the currently selected step back to the state it had when you selected it
- hold for about 1 second: clear the selected step

After a clear, the screen reminds you that the blue key can undo the erase.

10.2 Step tools picker

Press the far-right button on the third row while a step is selected to open the step tools picker.

Current tool choices:

- Vel
- Oct+
- Oct-
- Prob
- Tie
- Cancel/Finished

The picker screen shows:

- Tools #step number
- the selected step's current notes
- Vel Oct+ Oct-
- Prob Tie
- Cancel/Finished
- Press tool key

Current behavior:

- Vel: opens exact velocity entry for the selected step
- Oct+: transposes all notes in the selected step up 12 semitones and stays in the picker so you can apply another tool immediately
- Oct-: transposes all notes in the selected step down 12 semitones and stays in the picker so you can apply another tool immediately
- Prob: placeholder for future step probability editing
- Tie: placeholder for future tie behavior
- Cancel/Finished: exits the tool picker when you are done

The picker is only meant for the currently selected step.

10.3 Step velocity

Each step stores its own velocity value.

- range: 1-127
- default: 96

This follows normal MIDI note-on velocity style behavior.

How to edit velocity:

- select a step
- open the step tools picker
- choose Vel

The exact velocity screen uses keypad-style entry similar to exact length:

- number keys enter the value directly
- the first digit typed replaces the current value
- up to 3 digits are allowed
- values are clamped to 127
- <- removes the previous digit
- CANCEL exits without saving
- pressing the encoder saves and returns to the tools picker

Velocity affects:

- sequencer playback
- Tap Preview step previews
- live note audition while a step is selected
- MIDI output velocity
- onboard synth preview/play loudness approximation

11. Overview Screen

Press the second-row 9th key to open the note overview.

- It shows 8 steps per page.
- Press the same key again to move to the next page.
- Pages cycle through the 32-step pattern.
- Empty steps show as underscores.

The overview is meant as a quick readout of what is in the pattern without entering edit mode for each step.

12. Menu Structure

Main Sequencer menu:

- Keyboard
- Synth Options
- File Management
- Save
- Save New
- Load
- Revert
- Play/Stop
- Steps
- Direction
- Tempo
- Tap Preview
- Play Type
- Update Firmware

File Management submenu:

- Rename File
- Rename Folder
- Create Folder
- Delete File
- Delete Folder

13. Saving, Loading, And Reverting

13.1 Save

Save writes the current sequence back to the currently loaded file.

If no current file exists yet, Save creates a new file in /Sequences.

13.2 Save New

Save New opens the sequence browser so you can choose a folder, then name a new sequence file in that location.

13.3 Load

Load opens the browser and loads a saved sequence file.

13.4 Revert

Revert discards unsaved edits and reloads the last saved version of the current file.

If no current file exists:

- it may fall back to the old legacy file if present

- otherwise it resets to a blank/default sequence

14. File And Folder Organization

Sequences are stored in LittleFS under:

/Sequences

The current file path is remembered, so the last loaded sequence can come back on startup.

Files use the .hbseq extension internally.

The visible sequence name is the file name without the extension.

15. Renaming, Creating, And Deleting Files

15.1 Rename File

- browse to a file
- select it
- naming mode opens with the current file name filled in

15.2 Rename Folder

- browse folders
- enter the folder you want
- choose Rename This Folder

15.3 Create Folder

- browse to the parent folder
- choose Create Here
- naming mode opens

15.4 Delete File

- browse to a file
- select it to delete it

15.5 Delete Folder

- browse to the folder
- enter it
- choose Delete This Folder

Folder deletion is recursive, so deleting a folder removes its contents.

16. Naming Mode

Naming mode is used for:

- Save New
- Create Folder
- Rename File
- Rename Folder

16.1 Character layout

The on-screen keyboard layout is:

```
A B C D E F G H
I J K L M N O P
Q R S T U V W X
Y Z SPC - 1 2 3
<- CANCEL
```

16.2 Naming controls

- letter and symbol keys insert characters
- SPC inserts a blank space
- - inserts a hyphen
- 1, 2, 3 insert those digits
- <- deletes the previous character
- CANCEL exits naming mode without saving
- encoder press saves the name
- the physical CANCEL key is placed lower on the board to reduce accidental presses

16.3 Naming visuals

While naming is active:

- valid input keys are lit blue
- non-input keys are dark
- the display shows a blinking cursor in the name line

Maximum name length is 20 characters.

17. Performance Monitor

The sequencer has a temporary performance monitor overlay.

How to open it:

- press and hold the Play/Stop key for about 2 seconds

How it behaves:

- it appears while the key is still held
- it closes immediately when the key is released
- it does not replace the normal sequencer screen permanently

What it shows:

- AudioEng: approximate audio engine load percentage
- Mem: heap used versus total heap
- FS: LittleFS storage used versus total storage
- MIDI Q: current incoming MIDI backlog in pending bytes
- Drop: backlog episodes that hit the receive soft limit
- Late: backlog episodes that stayed pending long enough to count as delayed

While active sequencer overlays are open, the display is kept awake so edit screens do not fall asleep mid-entry.

18. Header Title And Unsaved Changes

At the top of the Sequencer menu:

- if no file is loaded, the title is:
Sequencer
- if a file is loaded, the title is:
Seq-FILENAME
- if there are unsaved edits, the title is:
Seq-*FILENAME

The star marks the sequence as dirty, meaning the current state differs from the last saved version.

19. What Is Stored In A Sequence File

The current save file stores:

- tempo
- active step count
- tap preview state
- play type
- direction
- the notes in each step
- the gate/length value for each step
- the velocity value for each step

20. Current Limits

- 1 track
- 32 steps
- 4 notes maximum per step
- naming uses uppercase letters plus a small set of extra characters
- no direct computer-drive mode for the sequence files yet

21. Practical Workflow Example

1. Enter Sequencer mode.
2. Press a step to select it.
3. Play notes on the lower keyboard area to build the step.
4. Turn the encoder while the step is selected to set note length quickly.
5. Repeat for other steps.
6. Press the top-right key to start playback.
7. Adjust Tempo, Steps, Direction, Tap Preview, or Play Type as needed.
8. Choose Save or Save New to store the sequence.

22. Quick Troubleshooting

If a step does not sound:

- make sure the step contains notes
- check that length is not 0%
- check whether Play Type is set to the output you expect

If edits disappear:

- use Save to write them to flash
- otherwise Revert or power loss can discard unsaved changes

If you cannot find a sequence:

- use Load and browse the /Sequences folders

- remember that the visible name comes from the file name